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DOOR ASSEMBLY FOR A SHELTER AND A SHELTER INCLUDING SAME

Abstract

A door assembly for a shelter, wherein the shelter comprises a frame assembly and a cover for covering the frame assembly, wherein the door assembly includes a door frame; a door coupled to the door frame, wherein the door is preferably of a flexible material that can be lifted to provide an opening into the shelter and can be lowered for enclosing the shelter, wherein the door includes a plurality of pockets; a plurality of elongated door members, each of which includes a first and a second end, wherein each of the plurality of elongated door members is positioned within a respective one of the pockets; a plurality of first couplers, each of which couples the first end of a respective elongated door member to a first side of the door frame; a plurality of second couplers, each of which couples the second end of a respective elongated door member to a second side of the door frame; and a door lifting/lowering assembly for lifting the door to provide the opening into the shelter and for lowering the door for enclosing the shelter. Also disclosed herein is a shelter comprising a frame assembly and a cover for covering the frame assembly; and a door assembly as disclosed above.

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Background/Summary

BACKGROUND OF THE INVENTION

[0001] The present invention relates generally to door assemblies for shelter structures and shelter structures including such door assemblies, and in particular, to an improved door assembly and shelter including such a door assembly. In the preferred embodiments, the shelter structure is a stand-alone outdoor structure constructed from a plurality of intercoupled steel pipes and covered with a flexible material. Preferably the door assembly includes a door frame likewise comprising one or more steel pipes also with a flexible material comprising at least part of the door, and among other things, a novel arrangement for lifting and lowering the door.

[0002] Door assemblies for shelter structures are well-known, examples being found in U.S. Pat. Nos. 1,788,651; 2,688,365; 4,379,478; 5,219,015; 6,152,207; and Reissue U.S. Pat. No. RE42,198. However, such examples are quite different from the door assembly disclosed herein and are not designed nor are contemplated for use with shelter structures of the type disclosed herein. Others have complicated and quite expensive mechanical and/or electrical assemblies for lifting and lowering the door. Others include complicated and heavy door assemblies that would in no way be conducive nor adaptable for a shelter structure of the type disclosed herein.

[0003] Others have door assemblies that simply are constructed and operated differently than those disclosed herein. For example, U.S. Pat. No. 7,913,711 describes a shelter of the general type disclosed herein. However, in this prior art construction, the door assembly comprises a retractable door arrangement in which the roll of flexible door material is preferably mounted on a spool so that the door can be extended off of the spool or retracted back onto the spool. A tube motor is described as a preferred means to raise and lower the door.

[0004] It is thus believed that the above-referenced examples either have deficiencies, differences and/or were designed with different challenges in mind. In the present invention, the ability to provide a door assembly that achieves all of the advantages provided by the constructions heretofore described, yet additionally is provided with a manual lifting and lowering assembly, while simultaneously is provided with a cost efficient, user-friendly and durable construction, is highly desirable. It is believed that all of the forgoing advantages and additional objectives as disclosed herein are provided by the novel and non-obvious door assembly disclosed herein.

SUMMARY AND OBJECTIVES OF THE PRESENT INVENTION

[0005] It is thus an objective of the present invention to overcome the perceived deficiencies in the prior art.

[0006] For example, it is an objective of the present invention to provide an improved door assembly for shelter structures and shelter structures including such a door assembly.

[0007] It is yet another objective to provide a method of constructing an improved door assembly for shelter structures and shelter structures including such a door assembly that is easy to assemble and is of a user-friendly construction.

[0008] Another objective of the present invention to provide an improved door assembly for shelter

structures and shelter structures including such a door assembly with a door that can be manually lifted and lowered, thereby being independent of the need of any electrical power.

[0009] It is yet another objective of the present invention to provide an improved door assembly for shelter structures and shelter structures including such a door assembly that is durable.

[0010] Still a further objective of the present invention is to provide an improved door assembly for shelter structures and shelter structures including such a door assembly that can be opened and closed by a user standing inside the shelter or outside the shelter, thereby providing further versatility and user-convenience to a user of the present invention.

[0011] Still further, it is an objective of the present invention to provide an improved door assembly for shelter structures and shelter structures including such a door assembly that provides for improved stability and structural integrity.

[0012] It is yet another objective of the present invention to provide an improved door assembly for shelter structures and shelter structures including such a door assembly that allows for relatively quick assembly and disassembly, while at the same time, achieving the other objectives set forth herein.

[0013] Yet another objective of the present invention is to provide an improved door assembly for shelter structures and shelter structures including such a door assembly that is both easy to utilize and manufacture and also that achieves all of the advantages and objectives set forth herein.

[0014] Further objects and advantages of this invention will become more apparent from a consideration of the drawings and ensuing description.

[0015] The invention accordingly comprises the features of construction, combination of elements, arrangement of parts and sequence of steps which will be exemplified in the construction, illustration and description hereinafter set forth, and the scope of the invention will be indicated in the claims.

[0016] To overcome the perceived deficiencies in the prior art and to achieve the objects and advantages set forth above and below, the present invention is, generally speaking, directed to a door assembly for a shelter, wherein the shelter comprises a frame assembly and a cover for covering the frame assembly, wherein the door assembly comprises a door frame; a door coupled to the door frame, wherein the door is comprised of a flexible material that can be lifted to provide an opening into the shelter and can be lowered for enclosing the shelter, wherein the door comprises a plurality of pockets; a plurality of elongated door members, each of which includes a first and a second end, wherein each of the plurality of elongated door members is positioned within a respective one of the pockets; a plurality of first couplers, each of which couples the first end of a respective elongated door member to a first side of the door frame; a plurality of second couplers, each of which couples the second end of a respective elongated door member to a second side of the door frame; and a door lifting/lowering assembly for lifting the door to provide the opening into the shelter and for lowering the door for enclosing the shelter.

[0017] In yet another preferred embodiment, the present invention is directed to a door assembly for a shelter, wherein the shelter comprises a frame assembly and a cover for covering the frame assembly, wherein the door assembly comprises a door frame; a door coupled to the door frame, wherein the door is comprised of a flexible material that can be lifted to provide an opening into the shelter and can be lowered for enclosing the shelter, wherein the door comprises a plurality of pockets; a plurality of elongated door members, each of which includes a first and a second end, wherein each of the plurality of elongated door members is positioned within a respective one of the pockets; a plurality of first couplers, each of which couples the first end of a respective elongated door member to a first side of the door frame; and a plurality of second couplers, each of which couples the second end of a respective elongated door member to a second side of the door frame.

[0018] In still yet another preferred embodiment, the present invention is directed to a door assembly for a shelter, wherein the shelter comprises a frame assembly and a cover for covering the

frame assembly, wherein the door assembly comprises a door that is liftable to provide an opening into the shelter and lowerable for enclosing the shelter, and wherein the door is comprised of a flexible material, and wherein the door comprises a plurality of pockets; and wherein the door assembly further comprises a door frame, wherein the door is coupled to the door frame; a plurality of elongated door members, each of which includes a first and a second end, wherein each of the plurality of elongated door members is positioned within a respective one of the pockets; a plurality of first couplers, each of which couples the first end of a respective elongated door member to a first side of the door frame; and a plurality of second couplers, each of which couples the second end of a respective elongated door member to a second side of the door frame.

[0019] The present invention is also directed to shelters comprising a frame assembly and a cover for covering the frame assembly; and the door assembly embodiments as disclosed and claimed herein.

[0020] The present invention is also directed to a shelter comprising a frame assembly and a cover for covering the frame assembly, and a door assembly as disclosed above.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0021] The above set forth and other features of the invention are made more apparent in the ensuing Description of the Preferred Embodiments when read in conjunction with the attached Drawings, wherein:

[0022] FIG. **1** is a perspective view of a shelter structure comprising a door assembly constructed in accordance with preferred embodiments of the present invention, wherein the door is in a closed position;

[0023] FIG. **2** is a perspective view of the shelter structure and door assembly of FIG. **1**, wherein the door is in an open position;

[0024] FIG. **3** is a perspective view of a feature of the front of the shelter and door assembly as constructed in accordance with preferred embodiments of the present invention;

[0025] FIG. **4** is a front view illustrating among other things, the door assembly as constructed in accordance with preferred embodiments of the present invention from a view taken from inside the shelter;

[0026] FIG. **5** is a perspective view of the door assembly of FIG. **4**, wherein the door is in an open position;

[0027] FIGS. **6** and **7** are views illustrating additional features of the door assembly constructed in accordance preferred embodiments of the present invention;

[0028] FIG. **8** illustrates yet additional features disclosed herein that assist in and provide for the lifting and lowering of the door;

[0029] FIG. **9** is a close-up showing a bottom corner of the door assembly, and in particular, a lower corner of the right and left side door frame members; and

[0030] FIG. **10** illustrates still further features of the door assembly constructed in accordance with preferred embodiments of the present invention.

[0031] Identical reference numerals in the figures are intended to indicate like parts, although not every feature in every figure may be called out with a reference numeral.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF THE PREFERRED EMBODIMENTS

[0032] Reference is first made generally to FIGS. **1-2**, which discloses a shelter, generally indicated at **100**, constructed in accordance with preferred embodiments of the present invention. Shelter **100** preferably includes a frame assembly comprising a plurality of intercoupled and/or interlocking steel pipes **105**, and a cover **110** for covering the frame assembly and specifically, the pipes **105**. Shelter **100** also includes a door assembly, generally indicated at **10**, also constructed in accordance

with preferred embodiments of the present invention. As will become clear to those skilled in the art, door assembly **10** of the preferred embodiments herein is believed to be novel and nonobvious over door assemblies in the prior art, and is further particularly adapted for use in a shelter, an example of which is generally indicated at **100**. The style, shape and size of the shelter **100** (apart from the door assembly **10**) itself is not material to the invention other than fact that the door assembly embodiments as disclosed herein must be constructed to be fitted therefor. Therefore, as should be understood from the following disclosure, the present invention is usable with shelters of many styles, shapes and sizes.

[0033] Turning now to certain particulars of preferred embodiments of door assembly **10**, reference is thus further made to the remaining figures.

[0034] As illustrated, in the preferred embodiment, door assembly **10** comprises a door frame, generally indicated at **15**, and a door, generally indicated at **20**, which is preferably comprised of a flexible material that can be lifted (e.g. FIG. 5) to provide an opening into the shelter **100** and can be lowered (e.g. FIG. 4) for enclosing the shelter **100**.

[0035] The door assembly **10** preferably comprises a plurality of pockets **25** that are spaced apart from each other (e.g. see FIG. 6) and a plurality of elongated door members **30** (e.g. see FIGS. 4 (with particular reference to members **30W**, **30X**, **30Y**, **30Z**), 6, and 7), each of which includes a first end **30A** and a second end **30B**, wherein each of the plurality of elongated door members **30** is positioned within a respective one of the pockets (e.g. FIG. 6). The members **30** assist in lifting and lowering the door **20** and provide integrity, stability, rigidity, and structural support to and for the door **20**.

[0036] The door assembly **10** also comprises a plurality of first and second couplers **35**, **40** as exemplary illustrated in FIGS. 4, 6, 7. Specifically, and as illustrated best in FIG. 4, each of the first couplers **35** couple the first end **30A** of a respective elongated door member **30** to a first side **15A** of the door frame **15**. Similarly, each of the plurality of second couplers **40** couples the second end **30B** of a respective elongated door member **30** to a second side **15B** of the door frame **15**. It should be understood that while FIG. 7 shows only one side of the door frame **15**, the references in FIG. 7 are indicated to show reference to the first and second couplers **35**, **40** and the corresponding structure. That is, since the construction of the door assembly **10** is the same on the first and second sides **15A**, **15B** of the door frame **15**, it is believed that one figure referencing both sides is both understandable to those skilled in the art and thus sufficient for disclosure purposes.

[0037] The figures also illustrate, with reference to FIG. 8 in particular, a door lifting/lowering assembly, generally indicated at **50**, for lifting the door **20** to provide the opening into the shelter (e.g. FIGS. 2, 5) and for lowering the door for enclosing the shelter (e.g. FIGS. 1, 4).

[0038] Preferred specifics of the above embodiments and features will now also be provided. For example, FIGS. 3 and 4 illustrates that the right side of the door frame **15A** comprises a right side door frame member **16** and that the left side of the door frame **15B** comprises a left side door frame member **17**. Furthermore, as illustrated for example in FIGS. 6, 10, each of the plurality of first couplers **35** are dimensioned to slide along (see arrows U, D) the right side door frame member **16** and each of the plurality of second couplers **40** are dimensioned to slide along the left side door frame member **17**. In a preferred embodiment, each of the ends of the plurality of first couplers **35** and the second couplers **40** are formed into a ring shape to facilitate the sliding of the respective couplers along (e.g. up and down) the respective right and left side door frame members **16**, **17**. Again, and for the avoidance of doubt, FIGS. 6, 10 show only one side of the door frame **15**, but since the features and construction on each side of the door frame are preferably identical, reference numbers to features on each side of the door assembly may be used in the same figure, and thus it is believed that one figure referencing both sides is both understandable to those skilled in the art and thus sufficient for disclosure purposes. For the avoidance of doubt, while “ring” shaped is a preferred shape, other shapes are contemplated such as oval, square, rectangular or the like.

[0039] As indicated above, the door lifting/lowering assembly **50** includes door lifting means for (i)

pulling the door **20** and/or one of the elongated door members **30** and causing the door **20** to lift to provide the opening into the shelter **100** and (ii) controlling the lowering of the door **20** to enclose the shelter **100**. In a preferred embodiment, the door lifting means includes at least one pulley **55** but preferably two (2) pulleys **55** preferably connected or coupled to the door itself as a user may connect or couple the one or more pulleys to holes made in the fabric of the door itself (alternatively, if additional support is needed, the pulleys could be connected, coupled or linked to one of the overhead pipes of the door frame or shelter structure itself), and a length of a rope **60** of at least enough length to span the height of the door and to be reachable and pullable by a user standing on the ground inside or outside the shelter, wherein pulling on the rope **60** causes the pulling of the door **20** and/or one of the elongated door members **30** and causes the door to lift to provide the opening into the shelter and/or controls the lowering of the door to enclose the shelter. [0040] Turning to a particular preferred embodiment, but which should be considered exemplary and not limitation, reference is again made generally to the figures and FIGS. **4** and **6** in particular. As shown in FIG. **4**, door **20** is provided with four (4) pockets **25**, i.e. pockets **25A**, **25B**, **25C**, **25D**. Correspondingly, in such an exemplary embodiment there are and will preferably be four (4) elongated door members **30** (i.e. members **30W**, **30X**, **30Y**, **30Z**). In a preferred embodiment, door lifting means provides for the rope **60** to pass through at least the first three (3) spaced apart pockets (i.e. pockets **25A**, **25B**, **25C**) and wherein the terminating end **60B** of the rope can be positioned just inside the last/bottom of the pockets **25D** such that when pulling on the first end **60A** of the rope **60**, the rope and the preferably “knotted end” **60B** will pull on the last of the pockets (i.e. pocket **25D**) and/or the terminating end **60B** of the rope can be tied to and/or otherwise coupled to the lowest/bottom elongated door member **30D** for lifting the door **20** to provide the opening into the shelter **100** and for controlling the lowering of the door **20** to enclose the shelter.

[0041] In such a way, it can be seen that various embodiments that can be constructed from the foregoing disclosure, wherein preferred embodiments of the invention contemplate at least N pockets **25**, wherein $N \geq 2$; at least M spaced-apart elongated door members **30**, wherein $M \geq 2$; and wherein the rope **60** or other lifting means passes through at least N-1 of the pockets (e.g. pockets **25A**, **25B**, **25C**), and wherein the terminating end **60B** of the rope **60** or lifting means (i) pulls the last (e.g. 4.sup.th) pocket (e.g. pocket **25D**) and/or (ii) is coupled to the last (e.g. 4.sup.th) elongated door member (e.g. **30D**) for lifting the door **20** to provide the opening into the shelter **100** and for controlling the lowering of the door **20** to enclose the shelter **100**.

[0042] While it is believed that the foregoing disclosure adequately and completely discloses the preferred embodiments of the invention, the following is provided for assurances thereof.

[0043] As should now be well understood, the present invention is generally directed to constructions of (and one or more methods of opening) an ingress/egress on a fabric and/or steel structure. The disclosed constructions and methods of opening reduce the force needed to lift the door **20** to its maximum and provides additional structural support to door frame structure of the shelter.

[0044] FIGS. **3** and **7** illustrate exemplary coupling arrangements **150** between on the one hand at least some of the intercoupled pipes and on the other hand, the right side door frame member **16** and the left side door frame member **17**. Such couplings **150** can be achieved by the use of various types of brackets, preferably made of metal. Preferably, the steel pipes are coupled to the ribs with a bracket and swaged pipe at the bottom.

[0045] FIGS. **9**, **10** are close-up views showing a bottom corner of the door assembly **10**, and in particular, to a lower corner of the right side door frame member **16** (FIG. **10**) and left side door frame member **17** (FIG. **9**), along with showing one of the floor rails **210** that are positioned along the surface of the ground upon which the shelter **100** is placed, as well as an optional anchor structure **215** (FIG. **9**). Specifically, FIG. **10** shows a respective side **16** of the door frame **15**, illustrating in particular spaced-apart elongated door members **30C**, **30D** both coupled to the side

door frame **16** by virtue of the couplers **40**. It should be understood that FIGS. **9** and **10** represent the constructions of both sides of the door frame and therefore is also deemed to illustrate both the first and second couplers **35**, **40** as would be coupled to the door frame members **16**, **17** and able to slide up and down thereon. Additional locking and supporting brackets and tightening assemblies are provided as would be understood in the art.

[0046] Preferably, the elongated door members **30** are made of PVC material.

[0047] As disclosed above, the door lifting means preferably comprises at least one pulley and the rope **60**. However, it should be understood that more than one pulley may be implemented, wherein the lifting means may comprise at least two (2) pulleys **55**, and wherein the rope **60** preferably would run through holes (e.g. holes **26**, FIG. **6**) in the preferably welded pockets **25** and run behind the PVC elongated door members **30** and terminate in the last pocket **25D** and/or around the last of the elongated members **30D** nearest the floor. An additional hole (not shown) may be provided at the top of the door to allow the rope **60** to run to the outside of the shelter **100** so it can be pulled and/or released by a person positioned outside of the shelter **100**.

[0048] The spacing between the PVC pipes determines the length of the sag of the fabric door **20** as it is pulled up. In an exemplary and preferred embodiment, the shelter **100** is a 13'×20'×9' structure, with the 9' height being sufficient to allow most SUVs, vans and/or trucks to fit within the shelter **100**. In such an example, the side zipper height on each side of the door **20** is preferably about 84", the door will be "bunched up" to about 10" in length of the door entry height, and the door opening is thus preferably about 74".

[0049] The present invention can also be constructed in many styles, such as by way of example and not limitation, "peak," "round," and/or "arch" and the sizes of such shelters are also numerous, including but not limited to 11'×20'×8'; 12'×20'×8'; 10'×20'×8'; 10'×12'×8.5'; 12'×24'×9'; 13'×20'×12'; 13'×20'×10'; and/or 14'×32'×12', just to name a few.

[0050] It should also be understood that feet and/or other supporting structure may be provided to the shelter **100** for providing support, lateral or otherwise, for the door assembly. Bolts/nuts, brackets and/or welding are the preferred means of coupling pipes and other structures together, but other equally acceptable and adequate means are known and could be employed as would be understood in the art. For the avoidance of doubt, the right and left sides of the door frame are preferably identically constructed.

[0051] As should now also be understood, various modifications and reinforcements can be made to the invention without departing from the scope thereof. For example, members **30** are preferably steel or PVC although the use of other materials are within the scope of the invention. The spaced apart pockets **25** are preferably welded as would be understood in the art, and are preferably at 19" high intervals on the door itself. In this way, the pocket height is preferably established to minimize the fabric sag of the door **20** as it is pulled up between one pocket and another. In addition, the pockets **25** provide for the elongated door members **30** to slide in from one end to another, acting as a rigid member to help with guiding the door vertically. Preferably, the elongated door members **30** can freely slide in the pockets **25** and fasteners or other locking means are not needed to maintain the members **30** within the pockets **25** by virtue of the unique implementation of couplers **35**, **40** at the ends thereof. That is, positioned at each of the respective ends of the elongated door members **30** are the aforementioned couplers **35**, **40**, which are preferably plastic caps with loops/rings on the ends as shown in the figures, where the loops/rings act as a guide to the door opening frame. The loops/rings on the couplers **35**, **40** may be rigid, or the loop/ring can be designed to rotate, allowing for easier functioning of the door. It should be understood that the terms "loop" and "ring" are meant to mean the same thing in this disclosure and can be used interchangeably herein without imparting any difference in structure or function therebetween.

[0052] The door lifting means preferably comprises one or more pulleys and/or one or more ropes on each side of the door **20** as illustrated in FIG. **4**, with the ends of the rope(s) terminating for example in or at the pocket **25D** and/or to and/or around the member **30** within the pocket **25D**

closest to the ground. However, these door lifting means are only by example and not limitation, as other structures, alone or in combination, can be used, such as string, cord, and/or a chain (linked or otherwise) made of metal, plastic or the like. And, while pulleys are preferred, other additional or substitute components may be used, such as by example and not limitation, loops, rings and/or other eyelet structures.

[0053] Preferably, the rope, string or other lifting means **60** is arranged to go through each pocket **25** through a hole behind the respective member **30** within the pocket **25**, although it is also contemplated that the lifting means **60** could go through each respective member **30**. Preferably, the lifting means **60** go through the pulleys **55** at the top of the door assembly **10**, then through a grommet (not shown) for guiding the rope, cord, string, chain or the like to the outside when the pulleys are on the inside of the shelter of course understanding that a reverse configuration and/or modifications thereto are within the scope of the invention. Preferably, there are two sections of rope, string or the like as indicated in FIG. **8** wherein a first section of rope is indicated by reference **60A**, a second section of rope is indicated at section **60B** and the two sections of rope are joined, e.g. by a knot, tie and/or otherwise to a third section of rope **60C** so that pulling on section **60C** lifts both sides of the door **20** simultaneously and at the same rate. In this way, the lifting means **60** (e.g. rope or otherwise) can be pulled and/or released by a person as discussed above. In this way, the means for pulling (e.g. the rope, string, chain, cord or the like) the door upwardly (i.e. away from the ground on which the shelter is positioned) provides an opening into the shelter and for lowering the door for enclosing the shelter.

[0054] To be sure however, the positioning of the pulleys, grommets and/or rope (or other means as disclosed herein) can be provided such that the lifting/lowering of the door is designed to be effectuated from inside the shelter **100**, as this is simply a design choice as to where to position such components. To secure the door when down, zippers (not shown) may be provided on each side of the door, but other options, such as Velcro, snaps, buttons or the like are also contemplated herein.

[0055] As would be known in the art and to the extent not dictated by function but rather by design constraints, combinations of metal, steel and/or plastic pieces may be used for the components disclosed herein. Preferably, however, all tubing is made of steel.

[0056] To this end, it can be seen that a method of constructing a door assembly for shelter structures and shelter structures including such a door assembly is provided.

[0057] It should also be understood that unless otherwise specified, the terms “coupled” or “connected” (or grammatical forms of each) may be used interchangeably herein and each and both and all of such terms and forms thereof are intended to mean and cover embodiments having a direct connection and/or connected through one or more intermediate members/structures or the like.

[0058] It will thus be seen that the objects set forth above, among those made apparent from the preceding description, are efficiently attained and, since certain changes may be made in the above constructions without departing from the spirit and scope of the invention, it is intended that all matter contained in the above description or shown in the accompanying drawings shall be interpreted as illustrative and not in a limiting sense.

[0059] It should also be understood that the following claims are intended to cover all of the generic and specific features of the invention described herein and all statements of the scope of the invention that as a matter of language might fall there between.

Claims

1. A door assembly for a shelter, wherein the shelter comprises a frame assembly and a cover for covering the frame assembly, wherein the door assembly comprises: a door frame; a door coupled to the door frame, wherein the door is comprised of a flexible material that can be lifted to provide

an opening into the shelter and can be lowered for enclosing the shelter, wherein the door comprises a plurality of pockets; a plurality of elongated door members, each of which includes a first and a second end, wherein each of the plurality of elongated door members is positioned within a respective one of the pockets; a plurality of first couplers, each of which couples the first end of a respective elongated door member to a first side of the door frame; a plurality of second couplers, each of which couples the second end of a respective elongated door member to a second side of the door frame; and a door lifting/lowering assembly for lifting the door to provide the opening into the shelter and for lowering the door for enclosing the shelter.

2-15. (canceled)
